

@shashikant.ai · DOTS

Free **Hermes Agent** setup + AI agent safety rules

From the reel "OpenAI dots: 4 things nobody is telling you".

By @shashikant.ai. From the reel "OpenAI dots: 4 things nobody is telling you".

Setup steps below are taken from Hermes Agent's official docs (checked 30 Sep 2026). I have not tested them on my own machine yet.

OpenAI dots in 20 seconds

- Launched 29 Sep 2026: an always-on AI agent with its own cloud computer, connected to 4,000+ apps.
- To be useful it needs your apps (Gmail, Slack, calendar), so it can read your mails and chats, even when you are not using it ("proactive research").
- Disconnecting an app does not erase what it already learned from it.
- Only on ChatGPT Pro (\$100 / \$200 / \$500 a month) or Business Premium. No India date yet.

The free alternative: Hermes Agent

- Open source (MIT) by Nous Research, 250K+ GitHub stars:
<https://github.com/NousResearch/hermes-agent>
- Runs on Windows, macOS, Linux, WSL2 and Android (Termux). Talk to it on Telegram, WhatsApp, Slack, Discord, Signal or email.
- The software is free. The AI model behind it is your choice: a paid API, a provider's free tier, or a local model (Ollama) on your own PC.

1. Install

Windows (PowerShell):

```
iex (irm https://hermes-agent.nousresearch.com/install.ps1)
```

macOS / Linux / WSL2:

```
curl -fsSL https://hermes-agent.nousresearch.com/install.sh | bash  
source ~/.bashrc
```

Or download the Hermes Desktop installer from <https://hermes-agent.nousresearch.com>

2. Pick a model

```
hermes setup      # guided setup wizard  
hermes model      # choose the provider / model
```

Options include OpenRouter, OpenAI, Anthropic, Hugging Face, Nous Portal, or a local model through a custom endpoint (Ollama, vLLM). The docs say the model needs at least a 64K-token context window.

3. First chat

```
hermes --tui
```

Success = the model name shows in the banner and it answers normally.

4. Connect Telegram or WhatsApp

```
hermes gateway setup  
hermes gateway start
```

- Telegram: create a bot with BotFather and paste its token.
- WhatsApp: pair by scanning a QR code (Baileys bridge), or use the WhatsApp Cloud API with a Meta Business account.

- Only you should be able to talk to it. Either allowlist your user ID (e.g. `TELEGRAM_ALLOWED_USERS=123456789`) or approve people one by one:

```
hermes pairing approve telegram <CODE>
hermes pairing list
```

By default it denies everyone who is not allowlisted or paired.

Docs: <https://hermes-agent.nousresearch.com/docs/getting-started/quickstart> and <https://hermes-agent.nousresearch.com/docs/user-guide/messaging>

AI agent safety rules (dots, Hermes or any agent)

1. **Keep approvals on.** In Hermes, set `approvals.mode: manual` in `~/.hermes/config.yaml` while you learn, so it asks before running risky commands. Never use `/yolo`.
2. **Connect only what the job needs.** One app at a time, not "everything".
3. **No bank, UPI or password access** until you trust it, and even then with a small limit.
4. **Remember:** disconnecting an app doesn't erase what an agent already learned. Think before you connect.
5. **Never allow all users** on a bot (`GATEWAY_ALLOW_ALL_USERS=true` is for testing only).
6. **Check what it did.** Read its activity/history regularly.

Security docs: <https://hermes-agent.nousresearch.com/docs/user-guide/security>

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